

ed to, we'll have to be very careful about controlling our dependence, and its evolution."

It seems that it's a foregone conclusion for Dennett that the Overbrain will happen. But then again, think of a now-famous article called *Why The Future Doesn't Need Us*, in Wired Magazine in 2000: it was written by Bill Joy, co-founder of Sun Microsystems. He began with, "Our most powerful 21st-century technologies—robotics, genetic engineering, and nanotech—are threatening to make humans an endangered species."

When it comes to speculation, the people up there seem as confused as the rest of us: some predict doomsday, while others speak blithely of better times to come. Regarding Dennett's comments, we agree that beyond a certain point we will not be able to understand the workings of the Overbrain, but we ask, isn't the dynamics of the Internet already beyond our comprehension? And as for control and dependence, what would happen to the civilised world if all computers were unplugged?

Coming back to Skynet, what if someone proposed to the Overbrain that it had the power to take over mankind? Wouldn't it turn evil at that point? Well, the Overbrain would be a reflection of the majority—one idea injected somewhere will not make a difference if the majority thinks (and hopes!) otherwise. But in any case, a doomsday question belongs in the realm of science fiction, where the Overbrain is assumed to have a consciousness and self-awareness and so on: we're assuming it *won't*. Think of the analogy with the human brain: *you* have a personality, your brain doesn't. Similarly, humanity might have a collective personality, but its Brain will not. Probably. Maybe. We hope so...

An important point we've just raised is that it's the view of the majority that will be reflected by the Overbrain. Your current brain state is an "average" of all the thoughts working away inside it; similarly, the Overbrain will reflect the "average" or "most common" view. Is that depressing? Will individualism die? The point here is that this is not radically different from the situation today. It's the majority that dictates that most people should do a 9 to 5 job, and we accept it as the norm. It's the majority that likes Microsoft and Windows, and that's why most of us use it!

As for individuality, it will always stand to be rewarded—recall what we said about the spreading of memes. If you have a great idea—a worthy meme—it will spread faster, more easily than it can today. Our view is that the Overbrain is something that will enrich our lives, much like the Internet has.

As a final point, one can always "opt out" of the Overbrain. Just because Google has a personalised search feature doesn't mean you have to use it—you can provide your login information only when you want to. Of course, opting out of the overbrain could be a hundred times worse than the situation today when your modem gives up on you, but at least you'll have the choice!

A Natural Progression

Heylighen said about the Global Brain that it could happen within "just five years." But he said that in 2000.

AI researchers are notorious for being overly optimistic and often hopelessly wrong with their predictions. We must distinguish well between fact and speculation. What we know for sure is that the Overbrain is the direct evolution of the Internet; that the need for communication can only increase; the need for coping with info overload can only increase; and that the need for sharing human intelligence can only increase.

Whether all this will indeed lead to an Overbrain, we can't say. But it's an idea. A meme, we should say. ■

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